The Obedience of Faith

A 12-Week Adult Bible Class

Format: 30-minute lecture + 10 minutes guided discussion, weekly **Audience:** Mixed adult Bible class (new and mature believers together) **Translation:** NET Bible **At-home component:** one light reading assignment per week, preparing the next lecture

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Course Summary Statement

The Good is not an idea to admire but the character of God to be conformed to. Scripture's consistent method for that conforming is sacrifice, tested obedience, and trained discernment. This course traces one thread from Genesis to the church age: God speaks, faith hears, and obedience makes the invisible visible. Along the way it asks the questions every believer eventually faces: What is worship, and how does it differ from religion? Why isn't sincerity enough? How does God test faith in every covenant, and what are the church's tests? How does a Christian learn to tell the genuine from the counterfeit? Where does teaching authority in the church come from, and how is God's created order reflected in His house? The course ends where Hebrews says maturity ends: not in knowing more, but in perceptions trained by practice to discern good and evil, and in becoming, by this time, teachers. Mercy first, altar second: everything asked in this course stands on a sacrifice already completed.

Course Map

Unit	Weeks	Theme
I. Foundations	1–3	The Good, sacrifice, and the failure of sincerity
II. Discernment	4–6	Two “righteousnesses”, the Berean method, love governed by truth
III. Testing	7–9	Faith tests across the covenants; the church's tests; the living sacrifice
IV. God's House	10–11	Apostolic authority; created order in the assembly
V. Commission	12	Households, teachers, and the obedience of faith

UNIT I: FOUNDATIONS

Week 1: Sacrifice Reveals the Good: The Four Layers

Aim: Teach the four-layer framework (Religion, Worship, Sacrifice, Obedience of Faith) and show why sacrifice is what makes worship visible.

Lecture flow

- (0–10) Moriah: God asks not for feeling but for "your son, your only son, whom you love" (Gen 22:2). Hebrews' reading: faith became visible at the raised knife (Heb 11:17–19).
- (10–30) The stack, one layer at a time:
    1. **Religion** (*threskeia*): the form (James 1:26–27)
    2. **Worship**: the disposition, "in spirit and truth" (John 4:23–24)
    3. **Sacrifice**: the cost that proves the disposition (Gen 22; Rom 12:1)
    4. **Obedience of Faith**: the settled pattern (Rom 1:5; 16:26)
- (30–40) Each layer can exist without the next: the Pharisee; sentiment (Ezek 33:31–32); Saul (1 Sam 15:22: "obedience is better than sacrifice").
- (40–45) Augustine's definition (*City of God* X.6): a true sacrifice is every work done that we may be united to God in holy fellowship.

Anchor texts: Gen 22:1–19; Heb 11:17–19; James 1:26–27; John 4:23–24; 1 Sam 15:22–23; Rom 1:5 **Discussion:** Which layer does religious activity most easily counterfeit? Why is a costless faith invisible even to the person who holds it? **Reading for next week:** 2 Samuel 6:1–11; 1 Chronicles 15:11–15

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Week 2: The Purpose of the Good

Aim: Establish that goodness is God's own character, its purpose is union with His people, and the course's controlling verse is Hebrews 5:14.

Lecture flow (45 min)

- (0–10) "Why do you call me good?" (Mark 10:17–18). Goodness has a source, not just a definition. Anything called good is good by participation in Him.
- (10–20) The purpose of the Good is God's purpose: image and likeness (Gen 1:26–27), conformity to the Son (Rom 8:29). Union, not admiration.

- (20–32) The problem: devotion is invisible, even to its owner. Introduce the course thesis: Hebrews 5:12–14. "By this time you ought to be teachers"; maturity = perceptions **trained by practice** to discern good and evil.
- (32–42) Course overview: the road from the Good, through sacrifice and testing, to trained discernment and commission. Grace stated up front: mercy first, altar second (Rom 12:1 "by the mercies of God").
- (42–45) Set the reading rhythm: one passage per week, read like a Berean.

Anchor texts: Mark 10:17–18; Gen 1:26–27; Rom 8:29; Heb 5:12–14 **Discussion (10 min):** When you say something is "good," what standard are you actually using? What would change if goodness were a Person's character rather than a measurement? **Reading for next week:** Genesis 22:1–19; Hebrews 11:17–19

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Week 3: Good Intentions Are Not Enough

Aim: Show from Uzzah and his companions across Scripture that sincerity cannot substitute for God's revealed will; the question of worship is "Has God spoken?"

Lecture flow

- (0–12) Uzzah and the new cart (2 Sam 6). The problem began before the touch: "we did not seek him according to the prescribed ordinance" (1 Chr 15:13). Not "we lacked sincerity"; we didn't do it His way.
- (12–28) The repeating pattern: Nadab and Abihu (Lev 10); Saul's two failures (1 Sam 13; 15); Moses striking the rock (Num 20, where even successful results don't justify disobedience); Jeroboam's practical worship (1 Kgs 12); Uzziah's incense (2 Chr 26).
- (28–38) The New Testament continuation: Mark 7:6–9 (human tradition as vain worship); Acts 5 (Ananias); 1 Cor 11:20; Paul's own sincere-but-wrong conscience (Acts 23:1).
- (38–45) The principle named: Romans opens and closes with the **obedience of faith** (1:5; 16:26). Faith hears, trusts, and walks in what God said; expedients may serve God's institutions, but never replace them.

Anchor texts: 2 Sam 6:1–11; 1 Chr 15:13; Lev 10:1–3; 1 Sam 15:22; Num 20; Mark 7:6–9 **Discussion:** Why does "it works" feel like divine approval? Where do we build "new carts" today: sincere improvements on what God prescribed? **Reading for next week:** Romans 9:30–10:13

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UNIT II: DISCERNMENT

Week 4: Two Righteousnesses, and How God Is Known

Aim: Ground the whole course in grace before pressing further: the difference between self-built righteousness and God's gift-righteousness, and the New Covenant promise of truly knowing God.

Lecture flow

- (0–15) The two righteousnesses: performance versus gift (Matt 5:20; Rom 10:3–4). A person can be serious, religious, sincere, and still miss God by building his own righteousness. "Prove yourself" versus "trust Christ."
- (15–30) How God is actually known: the New Covenant promise (Jer 31:31–34, where the law is written on hearts and "they will all know me"); new birth (John 3:3–6); the Spirit's witness (Rom 8:2, 9–11, 16).
- (30–40) Why this week sits here: everything in Units III–V describes obedience, and none of it earns standing. Obedience is the *shape* of faith, not its price. Israel was redeemed from Egypt before the wilderness tests, never by them.
- (40–45) Bridge: a gift this valuable must be discerned from counterfeits, which is next week.

Anchor texts: Matt 5:20; Rom 10:3–4; Jer 31:31–34; John 3:3–6; Rom 8:1–17 **Discussion:** How do pride and despair both grow from the same root of self-righteousness? What does daily dependence on given-righteousness look like practically? **Reading for next week:** Acts 17:10–12; 1 Corinthians 2:6–16

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Week 5: The Berean Method: Discerning the Sacred and the True

Aim: Teach the twin disciplines of eager reception and daily examination, the training regimen that produces Hebrews 5:14 discernment.

Lecture flow

- (0–12) The sacred under pressure: the gospel as revealed wisdom, not private opinion (Rom 1:16–17; 1 Cor 2:6–16). Spiritual things are spiritually discerned; the obedience of faith is how the sacred comes into focus.

- (12–25) The Bereans (Acts 17:11): **eagerly received** and **examined daily**: they fact-checked an apostle and Luke calls them noble. Both halves: soft heart, hard questions. Most people fail on exactly one side.
- (25–37) The verification toolkit: test all things (1 Thess 5:21); test the spirits (1 John 4:1); rightly handling the word (2 Tim 2:15); beware philosophy and empty deceit (Col 2:8); senses exercised by use (Heb 5:14).
- (37–45) Why daily: perception is trained, not downloaded. Reps (watching God draw the line between accepted and rejected worship across hundreds of texts) calibrate the eye like a tradesman's.

Anchor texts: Acts 17:11; 1 Cor 2:6–16; Rom 1:16–17; 1 Thess 5:21; 2 Tim 2:15; Heb 5:14 **Discussion:** Which half of the Berean posture is harder for you: receiving eagerly or examining daily? What was the last teaching you tested rather than absorbed? **Reading for next week:** Genesis 3:1–13; 1 Corinthians 13

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Week 6: Love, Compassion, and Truth

Aim: Show that biblical love is never separated from truth, and that compassion detached from God's word becomes a tool of moral inversion, beginning in Eden.

Lecture flow

- (0–12) The Fall as displacement: the serpent's method was not force but reframing: God portrayed as withholding, the fruit as beneficial. Eve evaluated God's command by the creature's claim (Gen 3:1–6). The core failure: God's word ceased to be the highest authority.
- (12–25) Love versus indiscriminate empathy: love "rejoices in the truth" (1 Cor 13:6). Christ's compassion never overruled His Father's will (Heb 4:15). Compassion seeks a person's ultimate good, not their immediate comfort; sympathy keeps one foot on solid ground to pull another out.
- (25–35) The manipulation pattern: "if you cared, you'd enable my choice": feelings elevated to final authority; guilt as control. God is compassionate *and* disciplines, judges, calls to repentance.
- (35–45) The guarded formulation for a mixed class: the believer never chooses between truth and compassion; the call is compassion firmly anchored in truth. Emotion is a good servant and a catastrophic master.

Anchor texts: Gen 3:1–13; 1 Cor 13:4–7; Heb 4:15; Rom 5:12; Eph 4:15 **Discussion:** Where is the line between compassion and enabling? How can a class member speak truth without weaponizing it, and love without surrendering it? **Reading for next week:** Deuteronomy 8:1–10; Genesis 22:1–2

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UNIT III: TESTING

Week 7: Faith Tests Across the Covenants

Aim: Establish the pattern: every covenant era carries tests of faith, commanded or providential occasions where trust in God's word must become costly action.

Lecture flow

- (0–8) The vocabulary: *nasah/bachan*, *peirazō/dokimazō*. God tests to prove and refine; Satan tempts to destroy (James 1:13; Job; Luke 22:31–32). A test is the scheduled occasion of sacrifice.
- (8–30) Era by era: Eden's command functioning as test (Gen 2:16–17, nearly costless to keep and therefore a pure test of trust); Noah and "things not yet seen" (Heb 11:7); Abraham, the first explicit test (Gen 22:1); Moses, with testing as covenant policy (Ex 16:4 manna; Deut 8:2: "test you to see if you have it within you to keep his commandments"; Deut 13:3 false prophets); Hezekiah left alone "to know his true motives" (2 Chr 32:31).
- (30–40) Christ the tested one: forty days answering to forty years, every answer from Deuteronomy 6–8, retaking Israel's failed exam and passing (Matt 4). The tested Son becomes "the source of eternal salvation to all who obey him" (Heb 5:8–9).
- (40–45) The hinge: the church's tests sit on the far side of a passed exam. Proving, not probation.

Anchor texts: Gen 22:1; Ex 16:4; Deut 8:2; 13:3; 2 Chr 32:31; Matt 4:1–11; Heb 5:8–9 **Discussion:** Why does God test people He already knows completely? What did the Hezekiah case reveal that forty faithful years had not? **Reading for next week:** Acts 2:36–41; 1 Corinthians 11:23–29

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Week 8: The Church's Tests: Obeying the Gospel and the Table

Aim: Answer the course's sharpest question: what specific obedience-of-faith tests does the New Covenant set for the church?

Lecture flow

- (0–10) The bridge texts: the gospel is something *obeyed* (2 Thess 1:8; 1 Pet 4:17; Rom 6:17), and apostolic commands are written "to test you to see if you are obedient in everything" (2 Cor 2:9).
- (10–22) The entry test: faith confessed (Rom 10:9–10), repentance commanded universally (Acts 17:30), baptism (Acts 2:38), with Luke 7:29–30 as the revealing text: refusing John's baptism *was* the recorded verdict on the experts' whole posture toward God's purpose. Colossians 2:11–12: the New Covenant marker standing where circumcision stood.
- (22–32) The recurring test: the Supper's commanded self-examination (*dokimazetō*, 1 Cor 11:28), with the covenant meal asking the covenant question weekly. The assembly itself (Heb 10:24–25); conditional forgiveness as diagnosis (Matt 6:14–15).
- (32–42) The continuous and providential tests: 1 John's "by this we know" (moral 2:3; relational 3:14; doctrinal 4:1–3); trials as the proving of genuineness (James 1:2–3, 12; 1 Pet 1:6–7); wealth as the church's manna (2 Cor 8:8: "I am testing the genuineness of your love").
- (42–45) The self-test and the final one: 2 Cor 13:5; Matt 7:21–27.

Anchor texts: 2 Thess 1:8; Rom 6:17; 2 Cor 2:9; Acts 2:38; Luke 7:29–30; 1 Cor 11:28; 1 John 2:3; James 1:2–12 **Discussion:** Which category of test does our congregation talk about least? What does weekly self-examination at the table actually involve? **Reading for next week:** Romans 12:1–2; Malachi 1:6–14

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Week 9: The Altar Today: Living Sacrifice, Royal Priesthood

Aim: Answer "do Christians offer sacrifices?": the atonement is finished once for all, and precisely therefore the worshiper now goes on the altar alive, body and mind.

Lecture flow

- (0–8) The guard first: made holy through the offering of Christ **once for all** (Heb 10:10). No altar we build adds to it.
- (8–20) The turn: sacrifice didn't end; it changed material. The substitute died in the worshiper's place; the Substitute having died, the worshiper offers *himself*, alive (Rom 12:1). The New Covenant sacrifices named: praise, good done, possessions shared (Heb 13:15–16); a holy priesthood (1 Pet 2:5).
- (20–32) The priesthood transfer: Malachi was written *to priests* about offering quality, and Peter made every believer a priest. "Offer it to your governor!" (Mal 1:8) arrives with no middleman. The standard crossed covenants untouched: the best, the whole, the unblemished. David: "I will not offer… sacrifices that cost me nothing" (2 Sam 24:24).
- (32–42) Body *and* mind: Rom 12:2's purpose clause: the mind is renewed "so that you may test and approve… what is good." The living sacrifice and Hebrews 5:14 discernment are

verses one and two of the same paragraph. Daily renewal in the Word is not preparation for the sacrifice; it is the daily portion of it.
- (42–45) Mercy first, altar second: a thank offering, not a payment.

Anchor texts: Rom 12:1–2; Heb 10:5–10; 13:15–16; 1 Pet 2:5, 9; Mal 1:6–14; 2 Sam 24:24 **Discussion:** If your time this week were an animal brought to Malachi's altar, what condition would it be in? What are the "first minutes" of your day currently given to? **Reading for next week:** 1 Corinthians 14:26–40; Jude 3

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UNIT IV: GOD'S HOUSE

Note for a mixed class: Weeks 10–11 handle contested ground. The tone throughout is what the material argues: authority located in the apostolic word, conclusions held with precision, honest acknowledgment of what Scripture does and does not say, and full honor for the substantial, recognized ministry of women in the New Testament.

Week 10: Apostolic Appointment: Where Doctrinal Authority Comes From

Aim: Establish that teaching authority in the church is conferred through the apostolic deposit, not generated by gifting, sincerity, results, or cultural trajectory.

Lecture flow

- (0–10) The underlying question: is authority *conferred* or *generated*? Every alternative in history takes the second answer: direct revelation (2nd c., 17th c.), demonstrated fruit (19th c.), reconstructed background or trajectory (20th c.). Different vocabulary, one move.
- (10–22) Paul closes the door in advance: "If anyone considers himself a prophet or spiritual person, he should acknowledge that what I write to you is the Lord's command" (1 Cor 14:37–38). Gifting does not adjudicate order, and the Corinthians' gifts were real.
- (22–34) Deposit and handoff: appointed, not attained (1 Tim 2:7); traditions delivered and maintained (1 Cor 11:2); entrusted to faithful people able to teach others (2 Tim 2:2); the faith once for all entrusted (Jude 3). The early church's question was never "who has the gift?" but "who was appointed?"; Origen concedes the gift and restricts the venue; Hippolytus ties ordination to liturgical function.
- (34–42) Why the slavery analogy inverts: Scripture never grounds slavery in creation; it grounds assembly order there twice (1 Tim 2:13; 1 Cor 11:8–9). Cultural anchors drag; creation anchors don't.
- (42–45) Bridge to next week: what, exactly, is restricted and what is not.

Anchor texts: 1 Cor 14:37–38; Rom 1:5; 1 Tim 2:7; 1 Cor 11:2; 2 Tim 2:2; Jude 3 **Discussion:** Why is "God is clearly using them" not, by itself, a warrant for office? Where do we feel the pull of results-based validation today? **Reading for next week:** 1 Timothy 2:1–15; 1 Corinthians 11:2–16

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Week 11: God's Created Order in the Assembly

Aim: Present the narrow, textually precise position on roles in the gathered church: the restriction concerns authoritative doctrinal teaching over men and the office attached to it (grounded in creation, not culture), alongside the full breadth of ministry Scripture shows women exercising.

Lecture flow

- (0–10) The storyline first: created equal in image and mandate, with ordered partnership before the fall (Gen 1–2); disorder entering through deception (Gen 3); Paul's appeal to that narrative (1 Tim 2:13–14), noting carefully what v.14 does *not* say: it describes the garden, not a general property of women, and Scripture assigns Adam primary responsibility (Rom 5:12).
- (10–24) The text and its scope: 1 Tim 2:11–12: "let a woman learn" (itself countercultural); the restriction on teaching-with-authority, read within the letter (teaching as doctrinal governance, 1:3; 4:11; 6:2–3; overseers "able to teach," 3:2). The reason given is Genesis, not Ephesus; Paul demonstrably knew how to give local reasons (5:14) and didn't use one here.
- (24–34) What is *not* restricted, stated as positively as Scripture states it: praying and prophesying (1 Cor 11:5: regulated, not forbidden); laboring in the gospel (Phil 4:2–3; Rom 16); Phoebe the *diakonos*; teaching in appropriate settings (Titus 2:3–5; Priscilla with Aquila, Acts 18:26). Holding 11:5 and 14:34 together: prophecy versus the authoritative weighing of it (14:29).
- (34–42) Honest scope ranking: eldership and governing doctrinal teaching rest on explicit texts; restrictions on baptizing or presiding rest on early practice, not command; say so plainly. Equality of being with difference of function, with 1 Cor 11:3's Trinitarian anchor.
- (42–45) The purpose: not control but communion: the household of God ordered as family under Christ, rehearsing restored creation.

Anchor texts: Gen 1:26–2:25; 1 Tim 2:11–15; 3:2, 15; 1 Cor 11:2–16; 14:29–40; Titus 2:3–5; Rom 16:1–16 **Discussion:** How does the "let a woman learn" command reframe the passage? Why does grounding matter: what's the difference between a rule from culture and a pattern from creation? Where must we be careful to claim only what the text claims? **Reading for next week:** Matthew 28:16–20; Hebrews 5:11–6:3

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UNIT V: COMMISSION

Week 12: Households and Teachers: The Obedience of Faith Completed

Aim: Land the course: God's order reaches from the assembly into the household, and maturity's destination is the Great Commission: "by this time you ought to be teachers."

Lecture flow

- (0–12) The household as the first congregation: Deut 6:6–9 (words on the heart, then taught); Gen 18:19 (Abraham chosen "so that he may command his children and his household after him"); Josh 24:15. For a mixed class: fathers and mothers, husbands and wives, single members and grandparents each carry a post: Eph 5:25–6:4; Titus 2; 1 Pet 3:7 ("so that your prayers will not be hindered," linking family treatment to access to God); 2 Tim 1:5 (Lois and Eunice: faith handed down by a grandmother and mother).
- (12–24) The pattern one last time: receive and hand on. Not invention: deposit and handoff, in the church and in the home. The blemished-lamb question asked of household time and attention.
- (24–36) The commission as the course's completion: Matthew 28:18–20: authority, go, disciples, baptizing, teaching, obey. "Teaching them to *obey*" is the obedience of faith in Jesus' own words. The Hebrews rebuke resolves into calling: "by this time you ought to be teachers" (5:12), and now the class has the meal to serve.
- (36–43) The completed stack: Heb 10:5–10: perfect form, perfect heart, full cost, settled obedience, once for all. Everything asked in twelve weeks stands on that. Mercy first, altar second.
- (43–45) Closing charge: one chapter, before the phone, eager and examining. **Offer your sacrifices with the obedience of faith.**

Anchor texts: Deut 6:6–9; Gen 18:19; Matt 28:18–20; Heb 5:12; 10:5–10; 2 Tim 1:5 **Discussion:** Who taught the faith to you, and what did it cost them? Whom will you teach, and what is the first step this month? **Reading:** none assigned: the course's standing assignment continues: one chapter daily, eager and examining.

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Weekly Reading Assignments (collected)

Before Week	Read
2	Genesis 22:1–19; Hebrews 11:17–19
3	2 Samuel 6:1–11; 1 Chronicles 15:11–15
4	Romans 9:30–10:13
5	Acts 17:10–12; 1 Corinthians 2:6–16
6	Genesis 3:1–13; 1 Corinthians 13
7	Deuteronomy 8:1–10; Genesis 22:1–2
8	Acts 2:36–41; 1 Corinthians 11:23–29
9	Romans 12:1–2; Malachi 1:6–14
10	1 Corinthians 14:26–40; Jude 3
11	1 Timothy 2:1–15; 1 Corinthians 11:2–16
12	Matthew 28:16–20; Hebrews 5:11–6:3

Notes

Resources

- Faith Tests Across Covenants
- The 3 Types of God's Will
- The Good - Terminology

Quotes

- "For obedience is distrust of oneself in everything, however good it may be, right to the end of one's life." - Step4 The Ladder of Divine Ascent, John Climacus